

Introduction

Strategy from context is the practice of generating strategy by borrowing structures, signals, and principles from domains entirely outside the one being solved. Instead of reasoning from within the problem, this approach looks outward — importing what other fields already know and redirecting it toward a new purpose.

Sun Tzu was an ancient Chinese military strategist and philosopher, best known as the traditional author of **The Art of War**. His work dates back to the 5th century BCE and demonstrates multiple forms of strategic thinking. In this memo, we will be looking at his depictions of “Strategy from Context”, especially from **Chapter 9: The Army on the March** from The Art of War.

Signals from Nature

I. Properties of Nature

Nature operates through its own independent laws that have nothing to do with warfare, armies, or human conflict. Two of those natural systems are especially relevant here.

- **Biological disturbance signals:** Animals and birds react immediately when something disrupts their environment — a predator, a large moving body, or even a sudden vibration. These reactions are consistent, involuntary, and directly proportional to the disturbance that caused them. They can therefore be read as precise signals of what caused them.
- **Physical properties of particles:** Dust behaves according to the laws of mass and motion. Heavier objects moving in a concentrated column raise dust in a tall, narrow peak. Lighter objects spread across a wide front produce a low, diffuse cloud. The shape of the dust is a direct function of what is moving beneath it.

II. Switching Context to Military Surveillance

1. A general cannot see into a forest, around a hill, or across a marsh. However, the natural world between the two armies has much more visibility and is always active and responding to whatever moves through it. By reading the precise pattern of a natural signal, the general can infer the exact state of an enemy which he cannot directly observe.
2. As Sun Tzu states: **“The rising of birds in their flight is the sign of an ambush.”** It means that if a flock of birds suddenly shoot upwards, it means that soldiers are in ambush at the spot beneath it.
3. Sun Tzu also states the inverse is true: **“If birds gather on any spot, it is unoccupied.”** which tells that the same signal works in both directions depending on its pattern.
4. Sun Tzu then uses science behind particle mass and how it signals enemy movement in Verse 23: **“When there is dust rising ... it is the sign of chariots advancing; when the dust is low, but spread over a wide area, it betokens the approach of infantry. ... A few clouds of dust moving to and fro signify that the army is encamping.”**
The shape of dust does not just inform; it prescribes action.

III. Why Is This a Strategy from Context?

- **The source domain is entirely non-military:** The properties Sun Tzu reads belong to ornithology, zoology, and atmospheric physics — none of which has any inherent connection to warfare. Sun Tzu does not invent new military knowledge; he borrows existing natural knowledge and redirects it toward a military problem.
- **The mapping is structural, not surface:** A large, heavy, concentrated moving body — whether made of horses, chariots, or soldiers — produces a specific and predictable physical signature. The signal and the army share the same underlying physics, not the same appearance. It is this structural correspondence, not any visible resemblance, that makes the context switch precise and reliable.

Conclusion

Sun Tzu’s central insight in this framework is that effective strategy does not always originate from within the domain it seeks to solve. By reading the behavior of birds, the flight of animals, and the shape of dust clouds, he imports knowledge from biology and physics into the problem of military intelligence.

The source is non-military, the mapping is structural, and through this, the surrounding environment becomes a free and reliable intelligence system. In this way, context is not treated as background noise to be ignored, but as a deliberate strategic resource which converts naturally occurring signals into sources of insight and makes intelligence not a matter of confrontation, but a result of observation.

References & Acknowledgements

1. “The Art of War” by Sun Tzu, Apple Books.
2. Use of AI: I used Claude for chapter selection and memo drafting & Cursor + Composer2 for interactive reading and editing.